

Cambridge IGCSE[®] (9–1)

SET E

FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH

0990/02

Paper 2 Directed Writing and Composition

INSERT

2 hours

INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading texts.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.

Read **both** texts, and then answer **Question 1** on the question paper.

Text A

The following passage is taken from an online article about the death penalty in Britain..

Let me make my position crystal clear upfront - I believe the death penalty is never justified and I'm thankful to live in a country with an independent justice system where it has long-since been abolished. But I'm never complacent in thinking it couldn't make a come-back. The arguments in favour of the death penalty are never far away, particularly when there is a shocking terrorist atrocity.

Who cares about terrorists, many might say? They deserve anything they get. But I see a danger which affects us all. It's a very slippery slope, no matter how extreme and horrific the crime. If it can be valid in one case — the argument can equally be made for other cases and before long the basic human right to life is denied. Opposition to the death penalty has to apply in all circumstances. It's absolute, no ifs, no buts.

A powerful reminder of why the death penalty has no place in our justice system is on our TV screens at the moment. 'Murder, Mystery & My Family' is an often poignant documentary series on BBC 1 re-examining historical British murder cases through the eyes of current relatives of those convicted and hanged. Expert criminal barristers and a retired Crown Court judge search for signs of miss-carriage of justice. One particularly worrying case they bring their forensic legal skills to bear on is that of William Burtoft, hanged for the brutal murder of elderly Frances Levin in her Manchester home in 1933. The only evidence against him was a confession he made to police.

It was the time of the Great Depression and it seems his only crime was to be homeless, alcoholic and vulnerable. The programme's legal experts found his confession to be totally unconvincing, with hallmarks it was written by a 3rd party (the police). And so a victim of the Great Depression became another victim of the prevailing legal system and was hanged.

It could be argued that such a case would never happen today. After all, police interviews are now videoed and convictions cannot be made solely on confessions. But I also know mistakes can and will happen.

There's an over-riding problem with the death penalty that no amount of safeguards and appeals can ever sweep away - it's final.

Text B

The following passage is taken from an online article arguing for the reintroduction of the death penalty.

'Why we should consider bringing back the death penalty'

The death penalty is a controversial subject. Since capital punishment ended in the UK in 1965, some have been glad to see the back of it, while others have called for it to be reinstated.

While more than most oppose the death penalty, I'm actually all for it. It's important to note that I would only be comfortable in imposing such a sentence on the criminals who have committed the most vilest of crimes, for example serial killers. 5

I understand taking a person's life shouldn't be a decision taken lightly, and many will oppose it all together. But does a serial killer - like Peter Bryan who murdered three people in London and ate their brains - deserve to be given a second chance? Does he deserve to live when three families have been traumatised and hurt in such a way their lives will never be the same again? My opinion is no. Serial killers like Bryan don't hesitate when it comes to killing another human being. So why should we flinch in taking theirs? 10

The Government says it opposes the death penalty around the world and has no plans to reintroduce it. But Conservative MP Sir John Hayes believes the country should give the matter further consideration. 15

He said: "We have got an issue in Britain with very serious crime. Barely a week goes by without hearing about some horrific child murder or old people being attacked and killed. Many of my constituents say that's partly because we don't respond appropriately. It seems to me there really needs to be a fitting punishment." 20

He added: "Look at the Westminster Bridge attacker; the British public would have been OK if he had received a fair trial and been hanged."

Westminster Bridge attacker Khalid Masood, who killed five people in the 2017 attack, was shot dead by armed officers after mowing down pedestrians and fatally stabbing PC Keith Palmer. 25

In my view we should give serious consideration to bringing back the death penalty. Yes it will be controversial. Yes there will be considerable opposition. But it's a sentence which, I think, is needed now more than ever.



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